More Justice, No Peace

The Voting Rights Act of 1965 and Victimization in the American South

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Question and Theory

Did democratization of the US South, through section 5 pre-clearance of the VRA, have a causal effect on homicide rates within counties of the former Confederacy?

Canonical literature in American politics suggests that democratic expansion may lead to reductions in homicide rates.

1. Elected officials will have incentives to demonstrate greater **responsiveness** to the policy preferences of formerly disenfranchised groups (Acemoglu and Robinson 2000; Besley and Coate 1997; Dahl 1971; Downs 1957).
2. Legislation may generate **policy feedback loops** where policies provide assets to formerly disenfranchised groups that bolster their political efficacy and communicate interpretive signals that encourage participation within state processes, thereby improving state capacity (Hartney 2022; Clinton and Sances 2018; Mettler and Soss 2004; Pierson 1993).

However, the comparative politics literature offers alternative mechanisms.

3. Transitions to democratic rule may increase or decrease civilians' exposure to victimization because democratic processes **break linkages between political parties and violent non-state actors** (Trejo and Ley 2026; Nieto-Matinz and Skigin 2023; Trejp et al. 2018; Dusek 2012).

This project builds on the **third** body of literature. I argue that section 5 pre-clearance led to the decline of local authoritarian enclaves that protected informal coercive institutions and degraded formal public safety institutions. The absence of informal institutions regulating violent behavior created greater opportunities for victimization.

Informal coercive institutions consist of fragmented networks of extrajudicial violent groups that provide enforcement services or rents to local elites in exchange for protection or payment.



Methods and Data

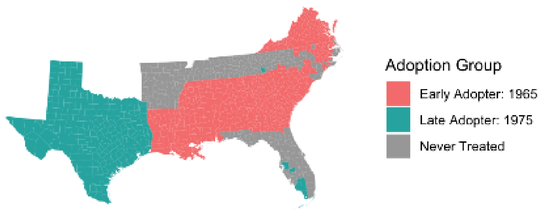
Flexible TWFE DiD and Long Difference DiD

$$HR_{it} = \alpha_i + \lambda_t + \beta(VRA_i \times Post_t) + \mathbf{X}i'\boldsymbol{\gamma}t + \varepsilon_{it}$$

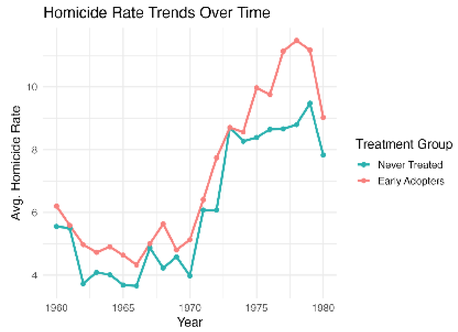
Model Components

HR_{it}	Homicides per 100k. Sources: FBI UCR and VS death certificates.
$VRA_i \times Post_t$	1965 section 5 coverage × post-treatment period. β: treatment effect. Source: DOJ.
α_i	County fixed effects.
λ_t	Year fixed effects.
$X_i'\gamma_t$	Pretreatment county covariates interacted with year indicators: population, urbanicity, and unemployment (1960); average police officers (1960–1964).
ε_{it}	Error term; standard errors clustered at the county level.
Indices	i = county; t = year.
Weights	Population size.
Study Period	1960–1980.
Primary Sample	1965 early adopters.

Former Confederate Counties under Section 5 Preclearance



Homicide Trends



Result 1: Increase in Aggregate Homicide

1965 adoption cohort

	UCR		Vital Statistics	
	TWFE DiD	Long Diff DiD	TWFE DiD	Long Diff DiD
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
VRA × Post	1.106**	2.300***	1.194***	1.737***
	(0.538)	(0.537)	(0.400)	(0.373)
Baseline covariates × year	X	X	X	X
County fixed effects	X	X	X	X
Year fixed effects	X	X	X	X
Observations	18,224	9,484	18,347	9,607
R^2	0.565	0.542	0.490	0.519

TWFE DiD: 1960–1980. Long Difference DiD: 1960–1964 and 1975–1980, retaining annual observations. Reference group: never-treated counties. Weights: 1960 total population. Standard errors in parentheses.
$^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Result 2: Increase in Race-Specific Homicide

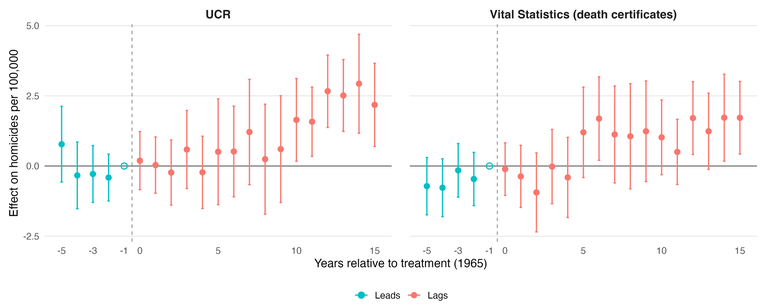
1965 adoption cohort; Vital Statistics

	Black homicide rate		White homicide rate	
	TWFE DiD	Long Diff DiD	TWFE DiD	Long Diff DiD
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
VRA × Post	1.529	3.725***	0.121	0.315
	(1.066)	(1.082)	(0.227)	(0.273)
Baseline covariates × year	X	X	X	X
County fixed effects	X	X	X	X
Year fixed effects	X	X	X	X
Observations	18,091	9,476	18,291	9,581
R^2	0.362	0.391	0.243	0.301

Rates per 100k residents of the corresponding race; 1960 race-specific population weights. Samples and periods as in Result 1. Standard errors in parentheses.
$^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.10$.

The Effect of the VRA on Aggregate Homicide Rate Per 100k

1965 adoption cohort | Full sample, 1960–1980

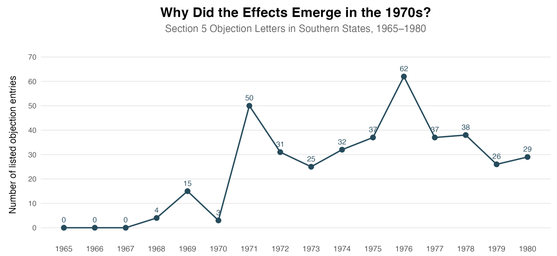


95% confidence intervals; standard errors clustered by county. Hollow point: 1964 reference year (−1). County and year fixed effects; baseline population, police staffing, unemployment, and urban share × year. 1960 total-population weights. Comparisons use never-treated counties.

Robustness Checks and Supplementary Analysis

- North Carolina model: 1965 adoption cohort.
  - UCR: TWFE 2.077 (SE 0.719); Long Difference 3.413 (SE 0.998).
  - Death certificates: TWFE 1.378 (SE 0.626); Long Difference 1.999 (SE 0.764).
- 1975 adoption cohort: supplementary TWFE analysis.
  - UCR: 2.572 (SE 0.468).
  - Death certificates: 2.653 (SE 0.397).
- Two measures of homicide.
- Leave-one-state-out exercise.
- Placebo treatment timing.

Mechanism Evidence



Result 3: DDD Goldwater Vote Share 64

1965 adoption cohort

	UCR TWFE DDD	Vital Statistics TWFE DDD
	(1)	(2)
VRA × Post	2.654**	3.375***
	(1.078)	(0.859)
Post × Goldwater share	0.303	0.451**
	(0.212)	(0.209)
VRA × Post × Goldwater share	−0.464*	−0.665***
	(0.258)	(0.231)
Baseline covariates × year	X	X
County fixed effects	X	X
Year fixed effects	X	X
Observations	18,224	18,347
R^2	0.566	0.491

1960–1980; reference group: never-treated counties. Goldwater vote share (1964) is centered at 20
$^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.10$.

Takeaways

1. Enfranchisement may not just be an insufficient channel to overcome persistent violence; it may also precipitate waves of unanticipated violence. Former authoritarian enclaves with more political support may experience less disruption and less violence.
2. While informal institutions of coercion have adverse effects on public welfare, their presence may still provide legible norms and rules that can be learned to better navigate violent environments.
3. Evidence that many democracies struggle to quell high rates of victimization over the long term and fail to preempt increases in violence during democratization challenges the validity of the domestic democratic peace.
4. **Policy implication:** Transitions from authoritarian rule likely require robust investments in state capacity and credible accountability for past abuses by corrupt elites to ensure public safety.

Notes

Section 5 preclearance: Required covered subnational governments to obtain federal approval before implementing any change to voting policies, procedures, or practices.

DOJ objection letter: A formal administrative response indicating that the DOJ denied preclearance to a proposed voting change, preventing its implementation unless the jurisdiction obtained court approval.